They Continued Stedfastly

The first church was devoted to God's word, fellowship, breaking of bread and prayer; it shared with those in need, praised God together, and God added to their number.

Main passage	Acts 2:42-47 (KJV)
Topic	Fellowship
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Devoted to the essentials	7 min
Teaching point 2: Sharing with those in need	7 min
Teaching point 3: Praising God, and God added	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What first drew you to this church, and what keeps you here?" Let several people answer. Often the answer to the first is a person or a welcome, and to the second, relationships. Today we look at the very first church, just days old, and what it devoted itself to.

Scripture (3 min)

Acts 2:42-47

42 And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in
prayers. 43 And fear came upon every soul: and many wonders and signs were done by the apostles. 44 And
all that believed were together, and had all things common; 45 And sold their possessions and goods, and
parted them to all men, as every man had need. 46 And they, continuing daily with one accord in the temple,
and breaking bread from house to house, did eat their meat with gladness and singleness of heart, 47
Praising God, and having favour with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily such as should
be saved.

Read the passage aloud.

Background (5 min)

Acts 2 describes the day of Pentecost, fifty days after Jesus' resurrection. The Holy Spirit came upon the disciples, Peter preached, and about three thousand people believed (2:41). Suddenly there was a large new community of believers in Jerusalem, many of them visitors from other lands.

Verses 42-47 describe the life of that first church. Luke presents it as a pattern of what Spirit-filled community looks like, though Acts goes on to show the church's problems too (5:1-11; 6:1).

Teacher note: "Breaking of bread" (vv. 42, 46) probably included both shared meals and the Lord's Supper. Christians understand the Lord's Supper in different ways; a separate lesson deals with that. Note too that the sharing of goods was voluntary (Acts 5:4); it was love responding to need, not a law.

Teaching point 1: Devoted to the essentials (7 min)

"They continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers" (v. 42). Four things marked the first church: learning God's word, sharing life together, eating together around Christ, and praying together. "Stedfastly" means they kept at it, not just on special occasions.

Supporting verses

Acts 2:42-43: And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers. And fear came upon every soul: and many wonders and signs were done by the apostles.

Hebrews 10:24-25: And let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works: Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some is; but exhorting one another: and so much the more, as ye see the day approaching.

1 John 1:3: That which we have seen and heard declare we unto you, that ye also may have fellowship with us: and truly our fellowship is with the Father, and with his Son Jesus Christ.

> *"They received it, retained it, and acted on its principles."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Acts 2:42

> *"Those who have given up their names to Christ must make conscience of hearing his word"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Acts 2:42-47

Handout blanks (answers)

They continued stedfastly in the apostles' **doctrine** and fellowship.

They continued in breaking of bread, and in **prayers**.

Teaching point 2: Sharing with those in need (7 min)

"All that believed were together, and had all things common" (v. 44). They sold possessions and goods to help "as every man had need." Fellowship was not just warm feelings on Sunday; it reached into wallets and homes. A church family looks after its members.

Supporting verses

Acts 2:44-45: And all that believed were together, and had all things common; And sold their possessions and goods, and parted them to all men, as every man had need.

Acts 4:32-35: And the multitude of them that believed were of one heart and of one soul: neither said any of them that ought of the things which he possessed was his own; but they had all things common. And with great power gave the apostles witness of the resurrection of the Lord Jesus: and great grace was upon them all. Neither was there any among them that lacked: for as many as were possessors of lands or houses sold them, and brought the prices of the things that were sold, And laid them down at the apostles' feet: and distribution was made unto every man according as he had need.

1 John 3:17-18: But whoso hath this world's good, and seeth his brother have need, and shutteth up his bowels of compassion from him, how dwelleth the love of God in him? My little children, let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth.

> *"they sold as much as was necessary in order to procure the means of providing for the wants of each other."*
>
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Acts 2:45

> *"It becomes Christians to be open-hearted and open-handed"*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Acts 2:42-47

Handout blanks (answers)

They parted their goods to all, as every man had **need**.

Christian fellowship reaches into our **wallets** and homes.

Teaching point 3: Praising God, and God added (7 min)

They met daily, in the temple and from house to house. They ate "with gladness and singleness of heart, praising God." They had favour with outsiders, and "the Lord added to the church daily such as should be saved" (v. 47). Notice who did the adding: the Lord. The church's part was to be the church; God brought the growth.

Supporting verses

Acts 2:46-47: And they, continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, did eat their meat with gladness and singleness of heart, Praising God, and having favour with all the people. And the Lord added to the church daily such as should be saved.

John 13:35: By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.

1 Corinthians 3:6-7: I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase. So then neither is he that planteth any thing, neither he that watereth; but God that giveth the increase.

> *"As the fountain whence they had derived all their spiritual and temporal blessings; seeing him in all things, and magnifying the work of his mercy."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Acts 2:47

> *"It is God's work to add souls to the church"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Acts 2:42-47

Handout blanks (answers)

They did eat their meat with gladness and **singleness** of heart.

The **Lord** added to the church daily such as should be saved.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Which of the four things in verse 42 is strongest in our church? Which needs the most attention?

Answers will vary; encourage honest, constructive discussion.

2. What does "fellowship" mean beyond coffee after the service?

Sharing life: meals, burdens, prayer, material help, accountability, encouragement.

3. How can our church care for members' practical needs today?

Meals, transport, benevolence funds, visiting, helping with jobs or repairs.

4. Why do you think outsiders looked favourably on this church?

Their joy, generosity, unity and sincerity were attractive and different.

Application (3 min)

Choose one way this week to strengthen fellowship: invite someone from church for a meal, check on someone who has been absent, or pray with another believer. Ask God to show you one practical need in the church family you can help meet.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, thank you for your church. Make us a people who continue stedfastly in your word, in fellowship, in breaking of bread and in prayer. Open our hearts and hands to one another's needs. Fill us with gladness and praise, and add to our number those who are being saved. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Acts 2:42

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Acts 2:42-47

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Acts 2:45

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Acts 2:47

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.